Task 5

Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide

Case Study: Phishing Attack on a College Student

Phishing is a type of cybercrime where attackers trick individuals into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, bank details, or OTPs by pretending to be a trusted source.

In this case, Riya, a college student, received an email that appeared to be from her university administration. The email claimed that her student portal account would be suspended unless she verified her details immediately. It included a link that looked legitimate.

Step-by-step, the attack worked as follows:

The attacker sent a fake but convincing email.
Riya clicked the link without verifying the sender.
She was redirected to a fake login page identical to the real one.
She entered her username and password.
The attacker captured her credentials and accessed her account.

Students and young internet users are common targets because they may not always verify sources carefully and often respond quickly to urgent messages.

The consequences were serious. The attacker accessed Riya’s personal data, misused her account to send spam emails, and attempted unauthorized transactions using linked services. She had to reset all passwords and report the incident, causing stress and temporary loss of access to important academic resources.

This case highlights the importance of verifying email sources, avoiding suspicious links, and enabling two-factor authentication to prevent phishing attacks.